

Genes and DNA

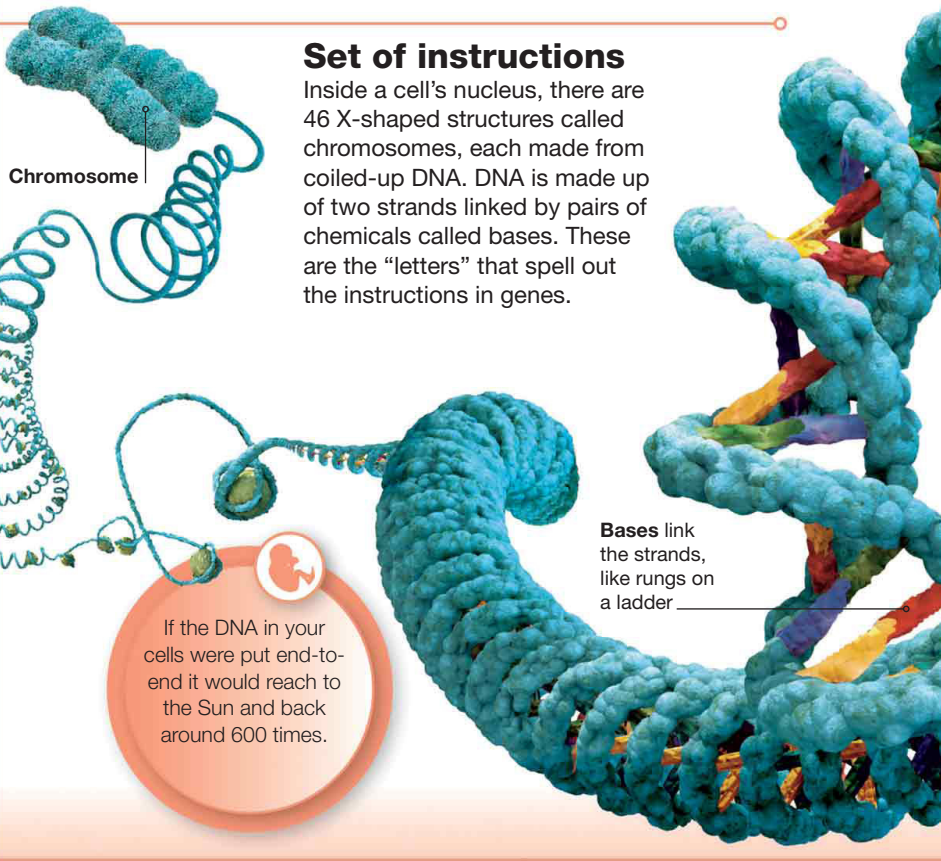
Every cell in your body contains the instructions needed to build and run the body. These instructions, which are inherited from your mother and father, are called genes. The 23,000 genes in each cell are made from a substance called DNA.

Set of instructions

Inside a cell's nucleus, there are 46 X-shaped structures called chromosomes, each made from coiled-up DNA. DNA is made up of two strands linked by pairs of chemicals called bases. These are the “letters” that spell out the instructions in genes.

Chromosome

Bases link the strands, like rungs on a ladder



If the DNA in your cells were put end-to-end it would reach to the Sun and back around 600 times.